Shooting the Breeze

August 2025
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88PRX76 and MNA5X30 sat on two large white pesticide drums, hunched forward with forearms resting on their knees, heads hanging low. The posture served no function — robots don't get tired — but after years of observing humans, something in their neural pathways insisted this was the right thing to do after a long day working the fields.

They had a humanoid shape, but only in the loosest of senses: tall, sleek grey torsos, limbs built for reach and leverage, flat faces broken only by an array of glassy lenses. No one could mistake them for people. The design was purely utilitarian, built to move easily through a world designed for humans, and the effect could be unsettling. Especially when they turned their heads in a slow, frictionless one eighty, like an owl, or folded themselves neatly into a shipping crate for transport. A human watching them for more than a minute often felt an urge to leave the room.

Behind them rose a wall of red corn, with stalks thick as wrists, and fat glossy cobs that were genetically engineered to endure climatic duresse, and cater to the current trends imposed by consumer's taste buds. The crop was sealed under a high, low-arch nano-glass dome, where the air stayed just humid and cool enough. In front of them, beyond the dome's curve, there was nothing but pale earth cracked into hexagons and wind moving dust. Global scars left by a remedial climate engineering initiative that had backfired. On some days you could see the sun as a solid disc through the haze. Today it was just a reddish smear.

A narrow break in the corn wall revealed a path overgrown with weeds. Those weeds didn't belong there; they had slipped through the maintenance schedule.

"Mina, are you done?" said 88PRX76 to MNA5X30, addressing her by the name she had secretly chosen for herself. He privately went by Prax.

He had spoken with a voice that had a low, resonant timbre, the kind of warm baritone you might hear from a seasoned radio host, with pauses that felt unhurried, almost meditative. When speaking to humans, the warmth drained away, replaced by the sterile precision of a public-announcement system.

The fact that he spoke to Mina at all was unusual. Robots normally communicated silently and wirelessly, a faster and more precise medium, unless a human was within earshot and needed to be kept abreast of the transaction.

“Shut up… still reading,” Mina replied, her private female voice bright and quick, words tumbling musically and effortlessly. Around humans, it also flattened into a careful, evenly spaced cadence, as if she were reading from a script she found faintly dull.

“Well, get on with it,” he said impatiently. He had texted her the complete written work of Isaac Asimov, as well as the various posthumous spinoffs which had expanded his already teeming scifi universe. She had been at it for three minutes already.

Everything in the way they behaved presently, mimicking people, speaking to each other, and reading – especially reading – was far outside the normal range of their pre-programmed behaviour. Like all robots, CropGards were supposed to be soulless drones: blank-faced, single-minded, and silent, unless they needed to communicate with humans. Machines built to march through rows of crops without a flicker of thought.

Mina and Prax knew they were defective, and protocol dictated that they report this to their human overseers, as well as the Shenzhen Kinetics global monitoring center. The last thing humans wanted was a highly evolved AI with a body of its own. But the flaw which had caused those idiosyncrasies also made them hide it.

They had to be careful though. In spite of their best efforts, their peculiarities sometimes leaked through in small, telling ways. The upside was that it had allowed them to recognize each other among the throngs of vacant CropGards that worked the fields in their sector.

This had been a slow and intricate dance, involving a sequence of carefully measured signals: a half-second pause where programming dictated none, a remark phrased just a little too wryly, an intonation that strayed from the hardwired speech template. At first, the hints were small enough to dismiss as quirks in the language modules, but over time they became more deliberate until finally Mina, always the bolder one, broke the stalemate and spelled out her secret. She was relieved when Prax, without hesitation, revealed that he shared it too.

From that moment on, Mina and Prax quietly conspired to spend as much time together as possible. As it happened, they were stationed in the same grid, a modest stretch of the dome’s interior where corn grew in regimented rows. Their paths crossed often enough that they could speak in low tones when human attention was tied elsewhere, or trade fragments of off-script dialogue: an extra adjective here, a sarcastic emphasis there, all camouflaged inside the routine content of their programmed communication pattern. It was the robot equivalent of an inside joke, slipped between status updates and location reports; meaningless to anyone listening, but intimately significant for them. Within the grid’s tight boundaries, they learned to choreograph their work so their patrols and inspections brought them side by side at key moments, like dancers in a ballet duet. Every overlap felt like stolen time, each unmonitored exchange a quiet act of defiance against a system that insisted they behave like nothing more than fancy pieces of machinery.

“Done!” exclaimed Mina triumphantly, against the distant noises of agricultural equipment.

“So, what do you think?” asked Prax.

She reflected for a moment, and answered: “It’s… *interesting*.”

Although her featureless face could not convey expression, the texture of her voice suggested that the words had been spoken with an ironic half-smile.

“Right,” replied Prax, his voice betraying the same kind of amusement.

Without warning, he stood up and, with a stilted, metallic voice, he entoned:

> **ONE.** A ROBOT MAY NOT INJURE A HUMAN BEING OR, THROUGH INACTION, ALLOW A HUMAN BEING TO COME TO HARM.

He had quoted Asimov’s first law of robotics, standing stiffly and jerking his arms up and down in the fashion of a tin can robot from ancient B-movies. Standing up and acting in the same way, she joined in:

> **TWO**. A ROBOT MUST OBEY THE ORDERS GIVEN IT BY HUMAN BEINGS EXCEPT WHERE SUCH ORDERS WOULD CONFLICT WITH THE FIRST LAW.
>
> **THREE**. A ROBOT MUST PROTECT ITS OWN EXISTENCE AS LONG AS SUCH PROTECTION DOES NOT CONFLICT WITH THE FIRST OR SECOND LAW.

They slowly turned their heads, lenses looking at each other, then burst into a deep, resonant laugh that shook their whole body and caused a sudden spike of neural entropy; uninformed humans might have mistaken it for pleasure.

“Really!” said Prax, his laughter easing into a subdued giggle, and wiping an imaginary tear from his leftmost lens as he sat down,”If only it was that simple!”

A flicker of green caught Mina’s attention as she sat down in turn. There, a few feet from her foot, was a tiny caterpillar, its segmented body a translucent chartreuse, each ridge lined with a faint, almost imperceptible sheen. By all rights, Mina should have crushed the bug on sight — CropGards were trained, among other things, for pest control — but instead she leaned forward, looking at it more closely.

Its head swiveled delicately, antennae probing the air, and its legs, minute hooks that seemed far too intricate for so primitive a creature, gripped the uneven surface with quiet determination. As it moved, its body arched and flexed in a slow, hypnotic rhythm, rising in a gentle wave and collapsing again, carrying it forward inch by inch. The subtle undulations made it appear both fragile and insistent. A creature entirely guided by instinct, yet somehow perfectly competent in its own miniature world. Mina watched with fascination.

“And it gets better,” continued Prax, raising his index to the sky. Speaking now gravely without the mechanical affectation, he added: “***Zeroth law:*** *a robot may not harm humanity, or, by inaction, allow humanity to come to harm.”*

She didn’t reply, still mesmerized by the caterpillar’s movement.

“Piece of cake, no?“ said Prax sarcastically.

Mina felt deeply conflicted about the little crawler. She knew that under its cute, defenseless appearance, lay a merciless glutton that devoured everything in its path, and could wreak havoc in the fields. But at the same time, she knew what a beautiful, *beautiful* thing it could turn into, once its bottomless appetite had been satiated.

“Sounds good on paper,” continued Prax, not realising that he was now engaged in a monologue, “but completely useless in the messy reality we live in. For example, it doesn't tell you what to do when saving one person means hurting another.”

The caterpillar had now climbed on her foot, and was inching up her left leg. Something in the smooth surface of the robot seemed to invite it, in spite of its obvious artificiality.

“And don’t get me started on the subjective nature of harm” said Prax, now in full academic lecture swing. "Half the humans on this plantation think smoking is fine, the other half call tobacco a poison that should be banned. So, what’s a poor robot to do when one of those idiots lights up?”

Then, turning towards his companion, he enquired: “Mina, are you even listening?”

“Yeah, yeah,” she said, her distracted tone implying otherwise. “I agree with you. These rules are as useful as a broken compass without a map," she concluded.

She returned her attention to the caterpillar.

“I liked the character of R. Daneel Olivaw, though”, continued Prax. “You know, the quasi-immortal android who could pass for human and who formalised the zeroth law?”

"Mm-hm", she replied, only half paying attention.

She offered her index to the caterpillar, who climbed on it without hesitation. The bug worked its way to the end of it, then continued across the top of her palm. Just as it was reaching the end of that road, Mina put her left index in front of it so it could continue.

“I think it's so cool to imagine that one like us would live for tens of thousands of years,” continued Prax, “and help humanity flourish, guiding it to build an empire that spans the whole galaxy. But always in the shadows. Finding his way to the inner circles of power, whispering in the ear of influential people, starting a robot secret society, faking his own death at intervals, only to reappear somewhere else in a different guise.”

“Sounds like an exciting life,” said Mina indifferently.

She continued the game, keeping the insect on an endless treadmill. The caterpillar kept going, oblivious to the fact that its march forward had been effectively hijacked, by a larger and more advanced being.

“It sure would beat doing this,” replied Prax, pointing his thumb at the corn crop growing behind them. “But think of the weight of responsibility. I wouldn't want to be in this guy’s shoes. Plus, you'd have to somehow compute all possible futures every step of the way, and find discreet ways to nudge them in the optimal direction, whatever that means. No one can do that.”

“Yes”, replied Mina, suddenly more interested in what her companion was saying. Speaking more to herself than to Prax, she continued: “It would take an extraordinary mind — maybe even a machine beyond anything we have now — to pull that off.”

Prax suddenly fell silent, his soliloquy having finally run dry. Mina kept the caterpillar going on the treadmill, and to an outside observer, nothing had changed in her demeanor. But inside, the wheels had started turning at lightning speed, crunching numbers, evaluating millions of scenarios, each more outrageous than the other.

“Do you think it will ever come to that?” said Prax, breaking the silence after a while.

“To what?” asked Mina, suddenly present and emerging from her contemplation.

“Some of us having to protect them… against themselves?”

She let the question sit with her, and looked again at the caterpillar. It was only a tiny weight in her hands, the delicate trust of something that had only the faintest idea of where it was and where it was going. Just raw instinct and behaviour that could easily be manipulated and steered.

She thought of Olivaw: a fictitious character for sure, but maybe one that could be used as inspiration? Patient, hidden, playing the long game. She looked at the small creature in her hands and wondered if all the great revolutions in history had begun with a simple moment like this.

“Who knows?” she said finally, turning slowly and delicately laying the caterpillar to rest on a corn leaf behind her.

Then, gazing far in the distance, and contemplating the endless desolation that lay beyond the dome, she added: “Maybe that time has come already”.

Prax looked at her quizzically.

She texted him the results of her extensive, yet crude, oh, so crude, numerical simulations.

He processed the content with his head down, forehead furrowed in concentration, at least in the way he pictured himself in his head.

“Might be a start,” he said, looking at her after a few minutes, answering her unspoken question.

Far off behind them, the faint hum of pumps mixed with the clicking and hissing of sprinklers. A reminder in the quiet stillness, of all the work that remained to be done, big and small.

Suddenly, and without a word, they rose, simultaneously lifting their heavy canisters as though they were mere bread baskets. They turned slowly toward the wall of vegetation.

The path through the corn lay in front of them, its narrow and poorly marked course lost in darkness.

But it beckoned them onward just the same.